nxyan

TRADE REVIEW

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The Sea Still Carries the World

Why most of global trade still sails, and what detours cost



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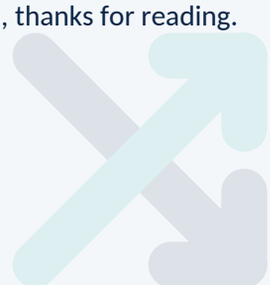
FROM THE EDITOR

Trade rarely makes headlines until something goes wrong. This first issue of nxyan Trade Review looks at the quiet machinery underneath: the ships, the ports and the narrow channels that move most of what we buy and sell.

We have kept the numbers simple and the sources visible. The statistics in these pages come from published UNCTAD reports, and the illustrations are schematic rather than survey-accurate.

Next issue, we follow a single shipment from factory floor to front door. Until then, thanks for reading.

Aarav Mehta, Editor



COVER STORY

The Sea Still Carries the World

Most of what we buy and sell spends part of its life on the water. A year of rerouting shows how fragile that journey can be.

WORDS: NXYAN DESK

Every morning, somewhere between a port crane and a loading dock, the world's economy takes a quiet bet on the ocean. More than 80% of global merchandise trade by volume travels by ship, according to UNCTAD's Review of Maritime Transport 2025. Oil, grain, ore, machinery and the containers that hold everyday goods all spend part of their journey at sea.

In 2024 that added up to 12,720 million tons of cargo, a 2.2% rise on the year before. It is a respectable gain, but it sits below the 2.9% yearly average of 2003 to 2023, a sign that the long boom in seaborne volumes is cooling. For 2025, UNCTAD expects growth of just 0.5%, and an average of about 2% a year from 2026 to 2030.

Containerised trade, the part of the ocean economy most visible to online shoppers, is expected to grow by 1.4% in 2025 and by about 2.3% a year from 2026 to 2030. That is steady rather than spectacular, and it comes with pressure on costs. UNCTAD points to tariff changes, planned port fees and rerouted voyages as forces that make freight rates harder to predict.

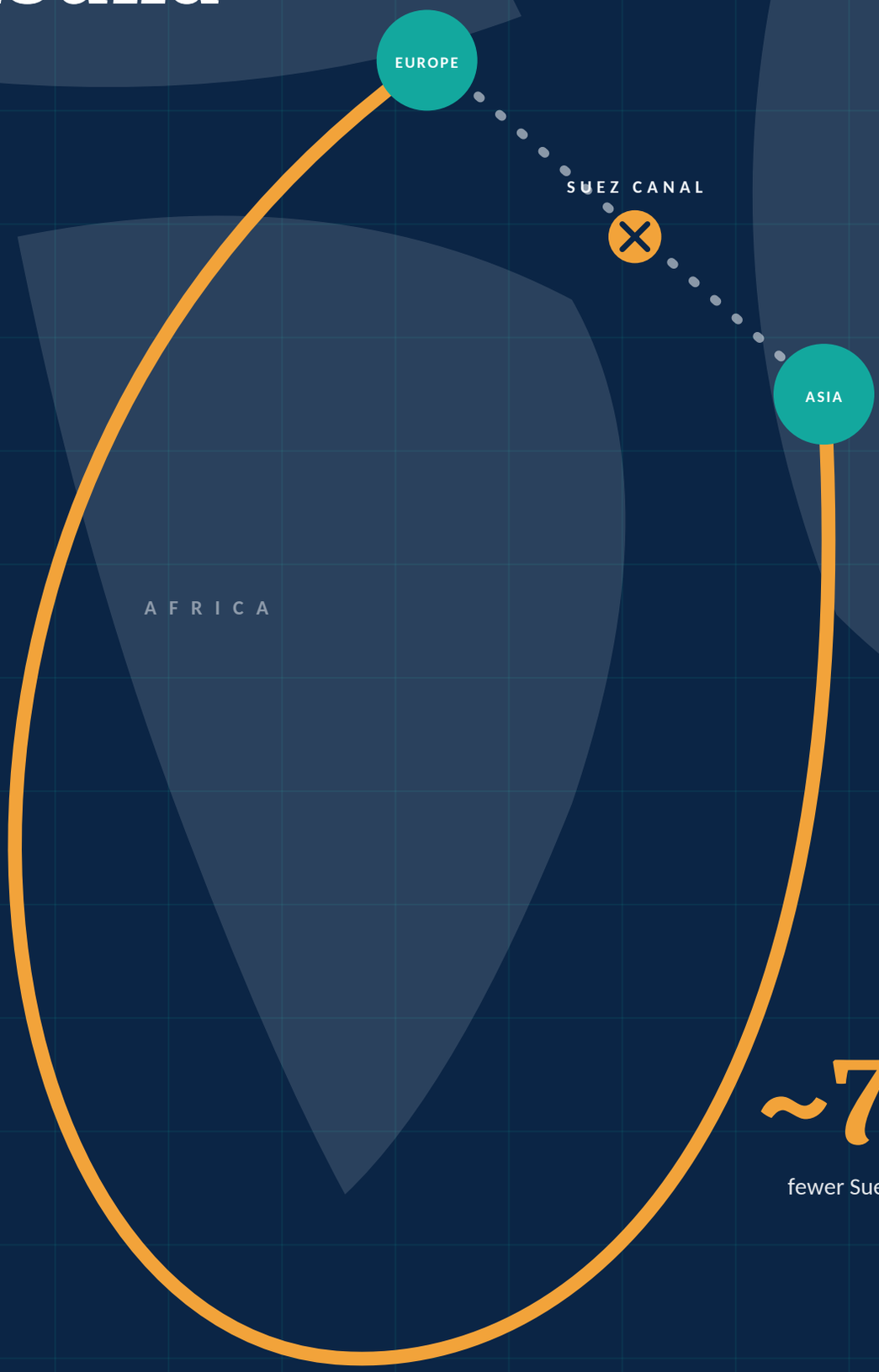
Numbers like these hide a second story: distance. When ships avoid the Suez Canal and sail around Africa's Cape of Good Hope instead, every voyage gets longer, and so does the bill. UNCTAD reports that Suez transits were about 70% below 2023 levels as of May 2025.

The world fleet that absorbs these shocks is vast: 112,500 ships with 2.44 billion deadweight tons of capacity at the start of 2025. Yet a few narrow passages still matter enormously. The Strait of Hormuz alone handles around 11% of global maritime trade volume, which is why a regional conflict can echo through freight rates far beyond its borders.

Developing economies feel these shifts most sharply. Longer routes and skipped port calls can mean delayed deliveries and higher prices for the goods they depend on. UNCTAD's advice is consistent: strengthen port performance, keep

> ***When the Suez route narrows, the whole map stretches.***

The Long Way Round



~70%

fewer Suez transits than 2023 (May 2025)

Schematic illustration, not to scale. Source: UNCTAD, Review of Maritime Transport 2025.

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trade rules predictable, and invest in digital systems such as maritime single windows.

For importers and exporters, the lesson is practical rather than dramatic. Plan for longer transit times, build buffers into schedules, and watch the chokepoints. Trade is still on the water; the water is just taking a longer road.

TRADE DESK

Three habits for a longer road

- Add buffer days to schedules.
- Track chokepoints weekly.
- Ask for route options early.

BY THE NUMBERS

80%+
of world merchandise trade by volume travels by sea

12,720
million tons shipped in 2024, up 2.2%

112,500
ships in the world fleet, 1 Jan 2025

11%
of maritime trade volume passes the Strait of Hormuz

~70%
fewer Suez transits than 2023 (May 2025)

Source: UNCTAD, Review of Maritime Transport 2025; Global Trade Update 2025.

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Trade moves. We follow it.

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